

Is a Business Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The complete profile — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest downsides, and what to ask before you commit.

7.6

AI EXPOSURE · BUSINESS ANALYST / COORDINATOR

where 10 is most at risk

Read this one first; send the student version to them.



Before you read this — a note for parents

You're likely reading this before your child is. That's normal, and it's worth pausing on how you use it.

Don't lead with the scores. If you open the conversation with a risk number, one of two things happens: they get frightened and shut down, or they get defensive about a decision they've already made. Neither produces a better choice.

The better approach: read this yourself first, then share it with them as *information you both get to react to*, not as a verdict you've reached.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation. We've set out what's known, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong.

Three things to keep in mind:

1. **They're choosing, not you.** Your job is to widen what they've considered. 2. **This is a starting point, not a ruling.** 3. **Don't do it all at once.**

A practical note: there's a separate short version written directly to them. Send them that one.

And one thing specific to business. This is the most-taken degree in the country, which means it is also the default choice — the thing people pick when they don't know what to pick. **That is the single most important fact in this profile, and it isn't about AI at all.** If your child is choosing business because they're genuinely interested in how organizations work, this document will help. If they're choosing it because nothing else stood out, the honest advice is to stop and look wider first.

The short answer

A general business degree with no specialization, no placement and no analytical depth is one of the weaker bets in this index. The versions that work are specific.

Business analyst and coordinator roles score **7.6** out of 10. General management with real accountability scores **4.9**.

And here is the thing that separates business from every other career we score: look at what's missing from that range. Nothing sits below 4.9. Every other profession in this index has a protected core. Business has a protected ceiling.

The scores

DESTINATION	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
General management / P&L ownership	4.2	4.5	4.9	+0.7	Moderate
Supply chain & operations	4.3	4.6	5.0	+0.7	Moderate
HR / people	4.7	5.0	5.3	+0.6	Moderate
Project management	5.3	5.7	6.1	+0.8	Moderate–High
Business analyst / coordinator	6.2	7.0	7.6	+1.4	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, bedside nursing scores 2.8, a service electrician scores 2.5, and entry-level software development scores 8.1.

Read the table this way: the spread is 2.7 points, which is narrower than law's or medicine's. That sounds reassuring and isn't. The range is narrow because the whole field sits in the middle — there is no safe end to retreat to.

Why business scores the way it does — the six factors

Here's how a business analyst answers them — the exposed end, and where most graduates start.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

More than almost any non-technical office role we score.

Report building and dashboard maintenance. Deck assembly. Market and competitor research. Process documentation. Requirements gathering and write-up. Meeting notes, trackers, status

reporting.

The pattern here is unusually clean, and it's worth stating plainly: almost everything on that list is what an entry-level business graduate was hired to do.

What resists: owning a number and answering for it, managing people, negotiating with someone whose interests differ from yours, and deciding what should be measured in the first place.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Bad, and worse than the automation alone would suggest — because two forces are compressing the same rung.

The first is automation. Analyst programs, coordinator roles and junior project management are precisely the automatable layer. Firms that once hired three graduates to build the reports now hire one experienced person with tooling.

The second has nothing to do with AI, and our framework doesn't measure it: **plain oversupply**. Business is the most-conferred bachelor's degree in the United States. There is no licensing body capping entry, no clinical placement bottleneck, no accreditation constraint on numbers.

Section 8 covers what the labour market data actually shows, because it's the most important evidence in this profile.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

Effectively none of it.

Business work is meetings, documents, spreadsheets and decisions. There is no physical component to protect it — and unlike law or accounting, no licensing to compensate.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At the top, genuinely. At the bottom, not at all.

A general manager owns a P&L and answers for it. That accountability is real, it attaches to a person, and it's the main thing holding the top of this profession at 4.9 rather than 6.5.

An analyst produces work someone else presents. The protection in business exists — but it is entirely seniority-dependent, and a graduate has none of it.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

No. Nothing.

This is business's defining structural weakness, and it is permanent. No professional body controls entry. No statute reserves any management activity to a qualified person. Compare accounting, where the audit signature is a legal monopoly, or nursing, where scope-of-practice rules and staffing ratios are written into law.

Business has no floor beneath it. Whatever protection someone has, they earned personally.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

At senior level often; at junior level rarely.

A managing director deciding whether to enter a market faces genuine novelty. An analyst producing a requested dashboard does not.

What the trend shows

Business analyst: 6.2 → 7.0 → 7.6. Up 1.4 points in three years.

General management: 4.2 → 4.5 → 4.9. Up 0.7.

Every destination moved, and none moved slowly. That is unusual. In most professions we score, the protected end barely shifts — bedside nursing moved 0.7, surgery 0.3. In business, even the most protected destination moved 0.7, because there is nothing structural holding it still.

The gap widened from 2.0 points to 2.7. The ladder's top is holding better than its bottom, but the whole ladder is drifting.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Real at senior level	Durable	Someone must answer for the number. Socially and commercially rooted.
Judgment under novelty	Real at senior level	Eroding	Decision support is improving; genuine strategic novelty is not automating.
Regulatory / licensing	None	n/a	No licence exists and none is coming.
Physical / embodied	None	n/a	Except in operations and supply chain, which is why those score marginally better.

The honest read. Business has two of the four protections, both of them seniority-dependent, and neither inherited from the profession. A doctor is protected on day one by a licence. A manager is protected only once they have something to be accountable for.

That is the central problem this profile is about, and it's why the entry-path question matters more here than the automation question.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Building the report	Deciding what the report should measure
Running the analysis	Interrogating an analysis that arrived pre-built
Coordinating the project	Owning whether it delivers
Producing the deck	Standing behind what it argues
Learning the business by assembling its numbers	Learning it... some other way, still being worked out

The last row is the real problem. Generations of managers learned how a business actually worked by building its reports — you cannot assemble a P&L pack for two years without

understanding the company. That was tedious, and it was also the education. Nobody has yet built a replacement.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Accountability for an outcome** — the willingness to own a number publicly. The single most protective attribute in this field. 2. **Managing people** — hiring, developing, and having difficult conversations. Barely touched by any of this. 3. **Negotiation** — dealing with someone whose interests genuinely differ from yours. 4. **Deciding what to measure** — the judgment upstream of the analysis, rather than the analysis itself. 5. **Verification** — knowing when a generated analysis is confidently wrong, which requires understanding the business well enough to smell it.

Notably absent: producing decks, building models and assembling reports. These were the traditional markers of a strong graduate hire and are the fastest-depreciating things on the list.

The evidence that matters most — and it isn't about AI

This is the section we'd point a family to first, because it's the strongest data in this profile and it comes from an independent source.

The **Federal Reserve Bank of New York** tracks labour market outcomes for recent graduates. As of Q1 2026:

- Recent graduate unemployment stood at **5.7%**, against a national rate of 4.2%
- **Underemployment — working in a job that doesn't require a degree — sat at 41.5%**
- Recent-graduate unemployment has now exceeded the national rate for five consecutive years, something that was almost unheard of between 1990 and 2018

A separate Burning Glass Institute and Strada study found **52% of bachelor's degree holders were underemployed a year after graduation** — and, importantly, that those who start underemployed tend to stay that way.

Now the comparison that should shape a decision. Nursing has the lowest underemployment rate of any major the New York Fed tracks, at **12.8%**. Against a graduate average of 41.5%.

That gap is not about intelligence, effort or prestige. It is about whether a degree points at a specific job that legally requires it. Nursing does. General business does not.

This is why we say business's problem is not primarily AI. Automation is compressing the entry rung, and it's real. But it's arriving on top of a graduate market where four in ten degree-holders are already working in jobs that don't need a degree — and business, as the most-conferred degree in the country with no cap on numbers, sits at the centre of that.

Our framework measures automation exposure. It cannot see oversupply. For business specifically, the thing we can't measure may matter more than the thing we can, and we'd rather say so than pretend the score is the whole picture.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The destinations are genuinely good. General management, operations leadership and commercial roles are well paid, intellectually varied, and carry real autonomy. Business and finance occupations are projected to grow 6–7% — solid, if unspectacular.

What people in these roles report as rewarding:

- **Breadth** — few careers touch as many parts of an organization
- **Visible impact** — decisions produce results you can see
- **Pace of progression** — competence advances faster here than in credentialed professions
- **Optionality** — the skills transfer across industries and geographies more easily than most
- **A realistic route to ownership** — business is one of the few paths where starting your own is a normal outcome rather than an exotic one

And one genuine advantage over the licensed professions: nobody can stop you. There's no board, no registration, no scope of practice. The same absence that removes the floor also removes the ceiling.

What's genuinely hard about it

Getting the first job. Covered above, and it's the dominant risk.

Proving value without a credential. A nurse is a nurse. A business graduate is a claim that has to be substantiated repeatedly, especially early.

The middle is crowded. Progression from analyst to manager is the bottleneck, and it's where the automation is landing hardest.

Outcomes are unusually school- and program-dependent. Not because of prestige, but because placement programs, employer relationships and specialization vary enormously — and those, not the degree title, determine the first job.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Business tends to suit people who:

- **Are comfortable being accountable in public** — this is the core protective trait
- **Genuinely like organizations** — how they work, why they fail, what makes people move
- **Can be useful without being told what to do.** The single biggest differentiator early on.
- **Are commercially curious** — interested in why something makes money, not just that it does

It's harder for people who:

- Want **clear structure and defined tasks** — that's exactly the automating layer
- Need a **credential to feel qualified**
- Chose it because **nothing else appealed.** This is the honest one. The default-choice group is heavily over-represented among the underemployed.

What else is moving this market

Oversupply is the dominant force, and it's structural rather than cyclical. Nothing caps the number of business graduates.

Skills-based hiring is being announced more than practised. A Burning Glass and Harvard Business School analysis found that removing degree requirements from postings hasn't meaningfully changed who gets hired.

Internships have become the actual filter. NACE's employer survey rates internship experience **4.5 out of 5** as a hiring factor — the highest-rated item. **In a field with no licence, the placement is the closest thing to one.**

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

The situation: business is where AI adoption is fastest, because there's nothing slowing it down — no regulator, no licensing body, no safety case to make. That cuts both ways. The exposure is higher, and so is the opportunity for someone who can direct it.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE BUSINESS GRADUATE LOOKS LIKE

1. Verify. Knowing when a generated analysis is confidently wrong. This requires understanding the business well enough to smell an implausible number — which is exactly the understanding the old report-building years used to produce.

2. Frame. Deciding what question is worth asking. The analysis is now cheap; knowing what to analyse is not.

3. Automate visibly. Being the person who rebuilds a manual process and can show what it saved. In a field with no credential, demonstrable results are the credential.

4. Communicate under scrutiny. Standing behind a recommendation when someone senior pushes back.

5. Own something measurable, early. The whole profile points at accountability. Anything that puts a graduate closer to a number they answer for moves them up the scale.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Before the degree: choose the program on placement quality rather than reputation. Section 12 covers what to ask.

During: take the quantitative modules seriously — that's the judgment layer rather than the reporting layer. Do the internship, then do another. Build one real thing with a measurable outcome.

Entering: aim for roles with a number attached, and prefer smaller organizations early where accountability arrives sooner. A graduate who owns something small at 23 is on a different curve from one who supports someone else's work until 27.

The routes in — and the versions that hold up

VERSION	ASSESSMENT
Business with a strong co-op / placement year	The single most important variable. It substitutes for the vanishing analyst rung.
Operations and supply chain	Leans physical, deals with real-world constraints, scores best in the field. Chronically under-chosen.
Business with genuine quantitative depth	The judgment layer rather than the reporting layer.
Explicitly entrepreneurial tracks	Building something is the one business activity that can't be entry-level-automated.
General business, no specialization, no placement	The weakest combination in this profile, and the most commonly taken.

Worth knowing: apprenticeship and degree-apprenticeship routes into management exist in several countries and are expanding. They pay rather than charge, and they solve the experience problem directly.

Where a business degree can take them later

The good news is genuine breadth: general management, operations, commercial and sales leadership, HR, project and programme delivery, consulting, entrepreneurship, and finance-adjacent roles.

The caveat that runs through this index applies with unusual force here. In most professions, moving away from the core raises exposure. In business there is no core to move away from — so the question isn't distance from the centre, it's proximity to accountability. Roles where someone owns a number score better. Roles that support other people's numbers score worse. That's the whole map.

What to look for in a business program

1. Placement — and whether it's guaranteed or competitive. A "placement year available" that only 30% of students secure is not a placement program. Ask for the percentage.

2. **Real employer relationships.** Named organizations, actual pipelines, and honest conversion data.
 3. **Quantitative content that isn't optional.** Statistics, econometrics, experimentation. This is the part that ages well.
 4. **First-destination outcomes — job titles, not employment rates.** "94% employed" is meaningless. What are they *doing*?
 5. **Specialization that's real.** An operations or supply chain pathway with genuine depth beats a general degree with a label.
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Questions to ask a business school

On placement:

- What proportion of students complete a placement or co-op, and is it guaranteed?
- Which employers took students last year, and how many converted to graduate roles?

On outcomes:

- What job titles did last year's graduates hold at six months? Read the actual list.
- What proportion were in graduate-level roles rather than any employment?
- How has that changed over three years?

On the curriculum:

- How much of the degree is quantitative, and is it compulsory?
- How does the program teach students to work with AI analysis tools — and to check them?
- What changed in the curriculum in the last two years?

Red flags: outcomes quoted only as employment rate; placement described as "available"; no named employer partners; a curriculum unchanged since 2022; heavy emphasis on generic "leadership" content with no quantitative spine.

Go deeper — further reading

- [The Labor Market for Recent College Graduates](#) — Federal Reserve Bank of New York. The single most useful link in this profile, and free. Unemployment and underemployment by major, updated quarterly, from a central bank rather than an industry body. Look up business against nursing and engineering before making any decision.
- [Talent Disrupted: Underemployment and the Value of a College Degree](#) — Burning Glass Institute and Strada Institute. Finds 52% of graduates underemployed a year out, and — more importantly — that starting underemployed tends to be sticky rather than temporary.
- [Class of 2026: A depressed hires rate is the cause of labor market weakness for young graduates](#) — Economic Policy Institute. A careful counterweight to AI-driven explanations: the hires rate has fallen broadly, which suggests a cyclical component alongside the structural one.

The counterargument — read this one:

- [Too many college graduates flood the white-collar job market](#) — Quartz.

The argument against our score is that we're attributing to AI what is really a supply problem. On this reading, business graduate outcomes were deteriorating well before generative AI existed, driven by the sheer number of degrees conferred and by employers raising requirements — and our 7.6 is measuring a labour market condition rather than a technological one.

Where we land: we think this is substantially correct, and we've said so in section 8 rather than hiding it. Business is the profile where our framework is least sufficient on its own. What we'd add is that the two forces compound rather than compete — oversupply meant graduates already needed a differentiator, and automation removed the rung where they used to acquire one. A reader should treat our score as one input alongside the New York Fed's underemployment data, not as a complete account.

Bottom line

Business is the field where the *program* matters more than the *subject*, and by a wider margin than anywhere else in this index.

The destinations are good. General management, operations and commercial leadership are well-paid, varied, and protected by real accountability.

The route is the problem, and it's a double one. Automation removed the entry rung, and it arrived on top of a graduate market where 41.5% of degree-holders are already underemployed. Business has a protected ceiling and no protected core — which means every bit of protection has to be earned, starting from a position of having none.

So the useful advice isn't "avoid business." It's: take placement more seriously than reputation, choose operations or genuine quantitative depth over general management studies, get accountable for something measurable as early as possible, and interrogate first-destination job titles rather than employment rates.

And one honest thing worth saying to a seventeen-year-old considering this because nothing else appealed: that is the single strongest predictor of a poor outcome in this profile, and it has nothing to do with AI. Business rewards people who are genuinely interested in how organizations work. It is unusually unforgiving of people who aren't.

Discussion questions

Part 1 — About the work itself

1. What made business appealing? Push past "it's flexible" or "good career" to something specific.
2. **The uncomfortable one, and worth asking gently:** is this a positive choice, or the thing left over after ruling other things out? Both are legitimate — but they lead to different advice.
3. What does a Tuesday look like in the job they're imagining? Compare pictures.
4. Are they interested in organizations themselves — why they work, why they fail — or in the outcomes a business career produces?

Part 2 — Reacting to the findings

5. Nothing in business scores below 4.9, while nursing scores 2.8 and a service electrician 2.5. Does that change anything?
6. The profile says business has a protected ceiling and no protected core. Does that land?
7. 41.5% of recent graduates are underemployed; for nursing it's 12.8%. What do they make of that gap?
8. Which matters more to them — the ceiling being high, or the floor being absent?

Part 2b — The harder conversation

9. What's the plan if they don't get a graduate role at six months? Have you discussed it? 10. Have you looked at actual first-destination job titles from their shortlisted schools, not employment rates? 11. Does the placement year exist, and is it guaranteed or competitive? Have you asked?

Part 2c — The other side

12. Of what people say is rewarding — breadth, visible impact, fast progression, optionality, ownership — which two matter most? 13. Looking at "who this work suits": which items sound like them? Answer separately, then compare. 14. Are they comfortable being accountable in public? Think of a real example.

Part 2d — The AI question, practically

15. Of the five capabilities — verify, frame, automate visibly, communicate under scrutiny, own something measurable — which appeals most? 16. The old way of learning a business was building its reports. If that's automated, how do they think they'd learn instead?

Part 3 — Testing it against reality

17. **The most valuable single action:** find someone 3–5 years into a business career and ask what they actually did in year one, and whether that job still exists in the same form. 18. Can they get any real commercial experience before applying — a Saturday job with responsibility, a small venture, running something at school? In a field with no credential, evidence is the credential.

Part 4 — About the program

19. Ask each school the placement and outcome questions from section 13. Compare the evasiveness as much as the answers. 20. Is there a genuine operations or supply chain pathway? Has anyone mentioned it? 21. How much of the degree is quantitative, and is it compulsory?

Part 5 — Widening the frame

22. If business weren't available, what would they choose? The answer usually reveals what they're actually drawn to. 23. Do they want *business*, or what business is made of? Someone drawn to it may want commercial thinking, working with people, building something, or simply a broad safe-sounding degree — and those lead to very different places, several of them cheaper and more protected. 24. Have they looked at operations, supply chain, construction management or the trades? All score better, and all are chronically under-chosen by academically capable students.

Part 6 — For the parent, alone

25. Is business the safe-sounding option here — for them, or for me? 26. If I'm honest, do I know what they'd actually do with this degree? 27. Am I comfortable that this is the most-conferred degree in the country, with no cap on numbers? 28. What's the one thing I most want them to understand — in a sentence, without a number in it?

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation, not a guarantee or a prediction. For business specifically, we've flagged that our framework measures automation exposure and cannot see graduate oversupply — and that the second may matter more than the first.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.